

Course Report

SK1127: Conflict and Conflict Resolution

Fall Semester 2024

Magnus Lundgren

1. Background

The course is the second course on the International Politics track on the second year of the “Statsvetarprogrammet”. It was offered for the first time. The course provides an introduction study of armed conflict in international politics. It aims to equip students with both theoretical and empirical knowledge about the causes, dynamics, and resolution of armed conflicts. Students are expected to critically analyze academic literature, apply theories to empirical cases, and develop their academic writing skills.

2. Course Content

The course included eight lectures and two seminars, with the seminars structured as interactive simulations to provide students with hands-on experience in conflict bargaining and mediation.

The course content was structured around three key areas. It began with an introduction to key concepts and empirical patterns in armed conflict, covering historical trends and variations in war across different regions. Students explored systemic and dyadic theories of war, focusing on power transitions, alliances, and the security dilemma, before moving on to domestic explanations such as political institutions, economic conditions, and selectorate theory. Individual and organizational-level explanations were also examined, with discussions on leadership, psychology, and bureaucratic decision-making. The second half of the course focused on conflict resolution and strategies for peace. Lectures covered topics such as mediation, sanctions, and peacekeeping operations. The course concluded with a discussion on the future of war, considering long-term trends and technological advancements in conflict.

A significant component of the course was the application of theories to practical scenarios. In the first seminar, students participated in a bargaining simulation designed to illustrate how war can arise due to information asymmetry and incentives to bluff. The second seminar provided a mediation exercise, where students acted as negotiators attempting to resolve a fictional interstate conflict.

The readings combined classic and contemporary literature, including Levy & Thompson’s “Causes of War” and Blattman’s “Why We Fight”, along with supplementary journal articles and case studies. This structure ensured students engaged with both foundational theories and selections of the latest research in conflict studies.

Three teachers were involved in the course. Magnus Lundgren handled lectures, course coordination, and one seminar group, including assessment. Jan Rustemeyer and Leonie Reicheneder handled one seminar group each, including assessment.

3. Students and grade distribution

The course had 40 registered students. Of these, 31 students received a passing grade by January 2025, and the remaining received their passing grades after completion or late submissions. Of the students who received their grades in the first round, 15 received a passing grade (G) and 16 a pass with distinction (VG). Of the students who received their grades in the late submission round, all but one received a G.

4. Course evaluation

The course received highly positive feedback from students, with 84.6% rating it as “Very Good” and 15.4% as “Rather Good”. In other words, 100% rated the course favorably. Students particularly appreciated the structured nature of the lectures and the relevance of the readings. Some comments highlighted that the combination of theory and empirical examples was effective in helping them grasp key concepts.

The lectures were well-received, with 92.3% of students rating them as “Very Good”, noting their engaging and informative nature. Some students found the pace slightly fast but still valued the content depth and clarity. Similarly, 25 out of 26 respondents (96.2%) rated the teaching as “Very Good”. The course literature was also positively reviewed, though some students found the volume of reading challenging. 42.3% rated the literature as “Very Good” and 53.8% as “Rather Good”, with many students finding Blattman’s book particularly engaging and accessible.

The seminar simulations appear to have worked very well, with 80% rating them as “Very Good” and 20% as “Rather Good”. Many students appreciated the interactive approach, finding the bargaining and mediation exercises highly educational and engaging. Some suggested scheduling the first seminar earlier in the course to facilitate a deeper understanding of the readings.

The research paper assignment was generally well-received, with 50% rating it as “Very Good” and 42.3% as “Rather Good”. Students appreciated the flexibility in choosing topics and the structured deadlines, with iterated submissions of the same text, though some suggested clearer guidelines on expectations.

Course organization, including scheduling and administration on Canvas, was rated by 84.6% of students as “Very Good”, with comments highlighting the ease of access to course materials and information.

Regarding workload, 50% of students found it “OK”, while 34.6% found it “Somewhat Too Demanding”, largely due to the volume of readings and simultaneous assignments. Some suggested reducing the literature load or spacing out assignment deadlines more evenly.

5. Possible changes in the next round

Overall, the course was well-received and functioned quite well, organizationally, so the ambition is to only make smaller changes for the next round, with a view of possibly making larger and more significant adjustment later on, once the course has been offered a few more times.

For the spring semester 2025, there will be minor changes to the schedule, literature, and seminar assignment, all to improve clarity and logistical efficiency. The research paper assignment will also be revised to more clearly communicate the analytical framework (number of theories, specifically) to be used, since there were many questions about this.

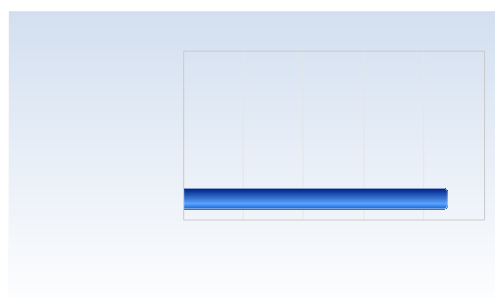
Appendix: Student evaluation

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Respondents: 40
Answer Count: 26
Answer Frequency: 65.00%

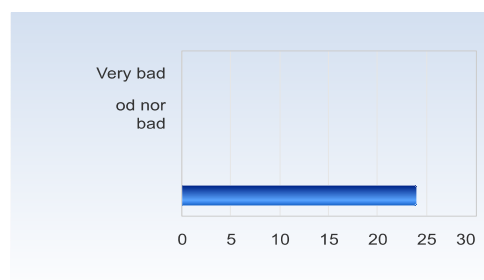
Overall, how would you assess the course?

Overall, how would you assess the course?	Number of responses	Cumulated responses
Very good	22 (84.6%)	22 (84.6%)
Rather good	4 (15.4%)	26 (100.0%)
Neither good nor bad	0 (0.0%)	26 (100.0%)
Very bad	0 (0.0%)	26 (100.0%)
Total	26 (100.0%)	26 (100.0%)



Overall, how would you assess the lectures?

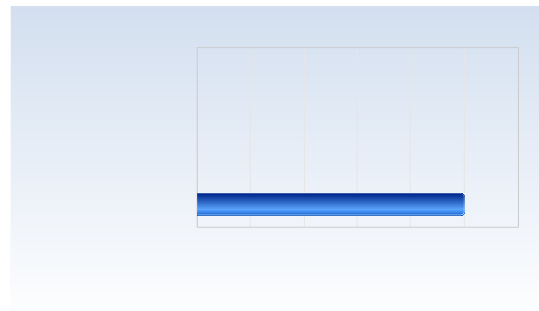
Overall, how would you assess the lectures?	Number of responses	Cumulated responses
Very good	24 (92.3%)	24 (92.3%)
Rather good	2 (7.7%)	26 (100.0%)
Neither good nor bad	1 (3.8%)	27 (103.8%)
Very bad	0 (0.0%)	27 (103.8%)
Total	27 (103.8%)	27 (103.8%)



	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coefficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quartile	Median	Upper Quartile	Max
Overall, how would you assess the lectures?	1.1	0.5	39.7 %	1.0	1.0	1.0	1.0	3.0

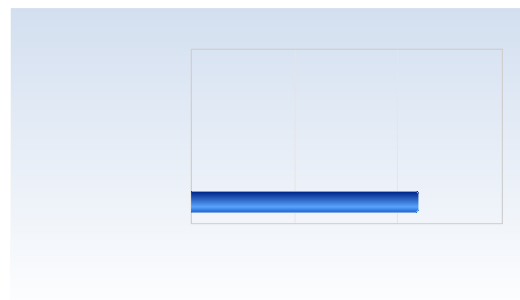
Overall, how would you assess the teachers?

Overall, how would you assess the teachers?	Number of responses	Cumulated responses
Very good	25 (96.2%)	25 (96.2%)
Rather good	1 (3.8%)	26 (100.0%)
Neither good nor bad	0 (0.0%)	26 (100.0%)
Very bad	0 (0.0%)	26 (100.0%)
Total	26 (100.0%)	26 (100.0%)



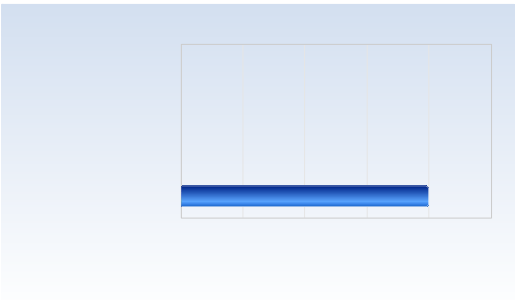
Overall, how would you assess the literature?

Overall, how would you assess the literature?	Number of responses	Cumulated responses
Very good	11 (42.3%)	11 (42.3%)
Rather good	14 (53.8%)	25 (96.2%)
Neither good nor bad	1 (3.8%)	26 (100.0%)
Very bad	0 (0.0%)	26 (100.0%)
Total	26 (100.0%)	26 (100.0%)



Overall, how would you assess the seminars?

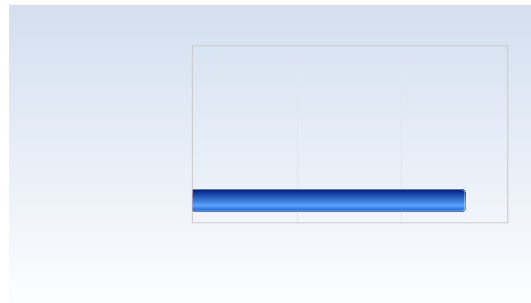
Overall, how would you assess the seminars?	Number of responses	Cumulated responses
Very good	20 (80.0%)	20 (80.0%)
Rather good	5 (20.0%)	25 (100.0%)
Neither good nor bad	0 (0.0%)	25 (100.0%)
Very bad	0 (0.0%)	25 (100.0%)
Total	25 (100.0%)	25 (100.0%)



Overall, how would you assess the seminars?	1.2	0.4	34.0 %	1.0	1.0	1.0	1.0	2.0
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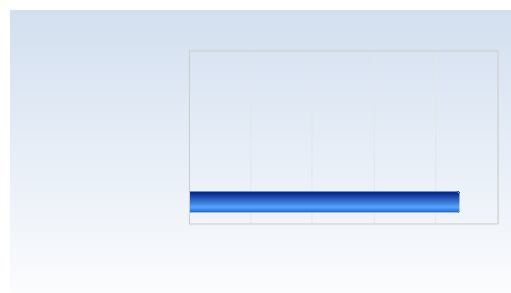
Overall, how would you assess the course research paper assignment?

Overall, how would you assess the course research paper assignment?	Number of responses	Cumulated responses
Very good	13 (50.0%)	13 (50.0%)
Rather good	11 (42.3%)	24 (92.3%)
Neither good nor bad	2 (7.7%)	26 (100.0%)
Very bad	0 (0.0%)	26 (100.0%)
Total	26 (100.0%)	26 (100.0%)



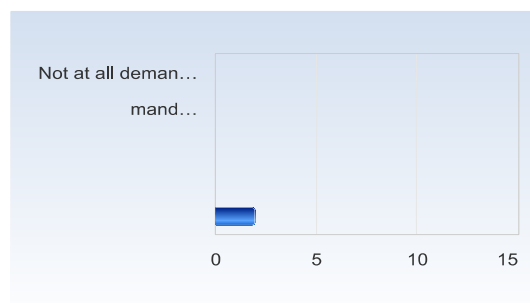
How would you assess the organization of the course, including the information on Canvas (informations, schedule, administration)?

How would you assess the organization of the course, including the information on Canvas (informations, schedule, administration)?	Number of responses	Cumulated responses
Very good	22 (84.6%)	22 (84.6%)
Rather good	4 (15.4%)	26 (100.0%)
Neither good nor bad	0 (0.0%)	26 (100.0%)
Very bad	0 (0.0%)	26 (100.0%)
Total	26 (100.0%)	26 (100.0%)



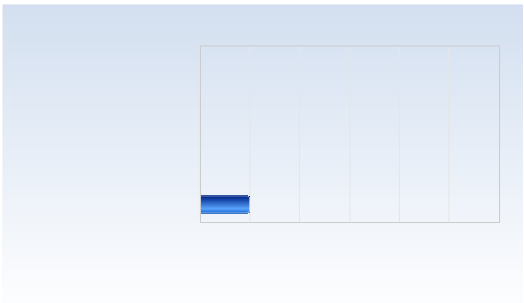
What is your assessment of the amount of work you have been requested to carry out during the course? Do you consider the course:

What is your assessment of the amount of work you have been requested to carry out during the course? Do you consider the course:	Number of responses	Cumulated responses
Much too demanding	2 (7.7%)	2 (7.7%)
Somewhat too demanding	7 (26.9%)	9 (34.6%)
OK	13 (50.0%)	22 (84.6%)
Not that demanding	4 (15.4%)	26 (100.0%)
Not at all demanding	0 (0.0%)	26 (100.0%)
Total	26 (100.0%)	26 (100.0%)



Please estimate how many hours, per week, you have spent on studying during the course?

Please estimate how many hours, per week, you have spent on studying during the course?	Number of responses	Cumulated responses
10 hours or less	2 (7.7%)	2 (7.7%)
11 - 12 hours	6 (23.1%)	8 (30.8%)
21 - 30 hours	8 (30.8%)	16 (61.5%)
31 - 40 hours	11 (42.3%)	27 (103.8%)
More than 40 hours	0 (0.0%)	27 (103.8%)
Total	27 (103.8%)	27 (103.8%)



How much did you learn during the course?

How much did you learn during the course?	Number of responses	Cumulated responses
A great deal	16 (61.5%)	16 (61.5%)
A fair amount	11 (42.3%)	27 (103.8%)
A little	0 (0.0%)	27 (103.8%)
Almost nothing	0 (0.0%)	27 (103.8%)
Total	27 (103.8%)	27 (103.8%)

